



IN THE WAKE · CRUISINGINTHEWAKE.COM

7-Night Western Caribbean

Symphony of the Seas
Sailing from Miami



Symphony of the Seas — Royal Caribbean's Oasis-class flagship

A Voyage Pack from [In the Wake](http://IntheWake.com)

Welcome

This pack exists to make one specific cruise easier to plan. It pulls together the ship-specific tips, port-specific advice, packing notes, and budget math that you'd otherwise have to assemble from a dozen browser tabs over the course of a month.

If you're sailing on Symphony of the Seas out of Miami on a 7-night Western Caribbean — whether next month or six months from now — this is everything we'd tell a friend who asked us how to plan it.

It is calm by design. There is no urgency, no upsell, no countdown. You can read it once and put it away, or you can use it as a working document for ten weeks. The site that produced this pack is independent — no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads. Your purchase is the funding model.

Includes an offline-capable Emergency Contacts section — fillable family handoff card, cruise-line and embassy numbers tailored to this itinerary, available offline after first load via [In the Wake's PWA](#). Designed to share with one trusted person ashore before sailing.

At a Glance

Ship	Symphony of the Seas
Cruise line	Royal Caribbean
Class	Oasis (third of five sister ships at time of build)
Length	1,184 ft / 361 m
Tonnage	228,081 GT
Decks	18 (16 passenger-accessible)
Passengers	5,518 (double occupancy); ~6,680 max
Crew	2,200

Year built	2018
Most recent drydock	March 2023 (Cádiz, Spain — technical refresh, hull repaint, minor amenity updates)
Departure port	PortMiami (Miami, Florida)
Itinerary length	7 nights / 8 days
Typical departure day	Saturday

Ports of call (varies by sailing — confirm yours): 1. PortMiami — embark Saturday afternoon 2. Sea day 3. [Roatan, Honduras](#) — Mahogany Bay or Coxen Hole 4. [Costa Maya, Mexico](#) — port 5. [Cozumel, Mexico](#) — port 6. Sea day 7. Perfect Day at [CocoCay, Bahamas](#) — Royal Caribbean private island 8. PortMiami — disembark Saturday morning

Section 1 — Your Ship: Symphony of the Seas

The shape of the experience

[Symphony of the Seas](#) is large in a way that’s hard to describe before you board. It’s organized into seven “neighborhoods” that each function almost as their own small ship: Royal Promenade (indoor mall), Central Park (open-air garden, mid-ship), Boardwalk (carnival-style entertainment), Pool & Sports Zone, Vitality Spa & Fitness, Entertainment Place, and Youth Zone. The neighborhood structure means you can have a quiet week or a high-energy week on the same ship without trying.

If you’ve never sailed an Oasis-class ship before: don’t try to “see everything” on day one. The first sea day is for finding your bearings. By Day 3 you’ll have a personal map of the ship — your favorite quiet bar, your pool deck, your dining route — and the size will start feeling like an asset rather than a maze.

For broader context on where the major lines are pointing their newest Caribbean ships in 2026, [Caribbean Cruise Trends 2026](#) covers the deployment shifts that affect what’s offered when you’re booking next year’s itinerary.

Size genuinely matters here, especially for first-timers — Symphony was the world's largest cruise ship at launch and still ranks in the top tier. The [Ship Size Atlas](#) compares Symphony to other Royal Caribbean ships and across cruise lines if you want to calibrate expectations. You can also follow Symphony's live position throughout your sailing in the [Ship Logbook](#).

Your cabin: the choice that matters most

Cabin selection on Symphony is consequential because the ship is so large. **Before you book, run the [stateroom sanity check](#)** — a four-question filter that catches the bookings most likely to leave a cruiser unhappy. Then, once you've chosen, the [cabin organization guide](#) covers the small-space pragmatics (over-the-door organizers, magnetic hooks for the steel walls, fold-up packing strategies) that make the cabin livable for a week. The categories that matter:

Interior with virtual balcony — Inside cabin with a screen that streams real-time outside views. Best value-for-money. Symphony has hundreds of these. If you don't need actual fresh air access, this is the practical choice.

Promenade view interior — Looks down into the Royal Promenade. Fun for first-timers but noisy at the start of the week and unflattering after the novelty wears off. Skip unless you specifically want it.

Central Park balcony — Balcony looks INTO Central Park (the open-air garden), not outward to the sea. Quiet, surprisingly pleasant, plant-filled, and decks 8–14 work well. Cooler than ocean balconies, often cheaper.

Boardwalk balcony — Balcony overlooks the Boardwalk neighborhood (carnival rides, AquaTheater). Loud in the evenings (Boardwalk shows, AquaTheater performances). Skip if you sleep early, choose if you have kids.

Ocean balcony — Standard balcony, faces the sea. Decks 7–14 are the sweet spot. Avoid Deck 6 aft (under the pool deck — noisy) and Deck 16 forward (close to the running track).

Junior Suite or above — Real value if you'll use the Suite Lounge (deck 17 forward), Coastal Kitchen (suite-only restaurant), or the priority embarkation/disembarkation. For a 7-night, this is worth thinking about. For a port-day-heavy trip, less so.

Pro tip on midship vs forward/aft: Symphony is so long that “midship” is genuinely different from forward or aft. Midship cabins (decks 6–14, sections roughly 9–11) feel less motion in any sea state and put you closest to the elevator banks that work hardest. Aft cabins are quieter at night (fewer people pass by). Forward cabins are closer to the gym/spa/Solarium.

Before you commit to a specific cabin number, the [Stateroom Sanity Check](#) walks you through accessibility, motion, noise, and view considerations against your booked deck and section — useful catch for the things that don’t show up in the deck plan.

What’s worth booking before you sail

Three things to handle in the Cruise Planner before embarkation:

1. **Specialty restaurant reservations.** On a 7-night you can usefully book 2–3 specialty dinners. [Coastal Kitchen](#) (suites only — skip if not eligible), Chops Grille (steakhouse), [Hooked Seafood](#), [150 Central Park](#) (the standout), [Izumi](#) (sushi/hibachi), [Sabor](#) (Mexican). Pre-book if you want a specific time; main dining room is unaffected.
2. **AquaTheater dive show.** *HiRO* runs in the AquaTheater. It’s a real reason to be on the ship. Reserve early — same-day standby works but it’s hit-or-miss in peak season. The 7 PM show is more popular; the 9:30 PM is less crowded and equally good.
3. **The Ultimate Abyss slide reservation (if open during your sailing).** Confirm availability with the Cruise Planner — operating hours and reservation windows shift seasonally. Same applies to Flowrider and Zip Line: walk-up most days, reserve only if a specific time matters to you.

Drink package math for THIS itinerary

A 7-night Symphony sailing has 4 sea-day-style days (Sat afternoon embark, full sea day, Sat-morning disembark, plus stretched-out lounge time on port days when you’re back onboard by 5 PM). The sailings have 3 actual port days where you’re onshore most of the time.

Royal Caribbean's *Deluxe Beverage Package* on Symphony typically prices around \$80–95/person/day plus 18% gratuity = roughly \$94–112/person/day all-in. For 7 nights, that's \$660–780/person.

Break-even math (using \$100/person/day as a working figure):

- A frozen drink at the pool: ~\$13–14 + tip = \$16
- A glass of wine at dinner: ~\$13 + tip = \$15
- A beer: ~\$8 + tip = \$9
- Specialty coffee: ~\$6 + tip = \$7
- Bottled water: ~\$5 + tip = \$6

To break even on the Deluxe package at \$100/person/day, you'd need roughly: 2 cocktails + 1 wine + 1 beer + 1 coffee + 1 water per day ($\approx$ \$69 + tip). That's a real day's drinking. Most cruisers don't hit this on port days.

The honest answer: Deluxe is worth it if you reliably drink 5+ alcoholic beverages per day during a 7-night. *Refreshment Package* (no alcohol — sodas, premium juices, specialty coffees, smoothies, bottled water) at ~\$30–35/day is the better deal for non-drinkers and families.

If you'd rather work the numbers against your actual drinking pattern instead of generic break-even math, drop your day-by-day intake into the [Drink Calculator](#) — it works across cruise lines and answers the package-or-pay-as-you-go question in seconds. The companion article [Is the drink package worth it?](#) walks through the breakeven math with worked examples. The [Drink Packages comparison](#) lays Royal's tiers next to other lines if you're cruise-shopping.

Pro tip: Royal allows you to bring 1 bottle of wine OR 1 bottle of champagne per stateroom, sealed, in carry-on at embarkation. Bring it. Bring also up to 12 unopened bottles/cans of non-alcoholic beverages per stateroom (water, soda, sparkling water).

Onboard rhythm: what's worth doing on sea days

The two full sea days are where Symphony differentiates from a smaller ship. Things worth doing:

- **AquaTheater shows** (HiRO is the headliner; check Cruise Compass)
- **Comedy Live** (intimate venue, nightly, calendar varies)

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- **Studio B ice show** (high-production skating on a regulation-size rink — confirm current show title in your Cruise Compass)
 - **Bionic Bar** (drinks made by robots; absurd, fun for first-timers)
 - **Ultimate Abyss** (10-story slide; the line is short on sea-day mornings)
 - **Flowrider** (surfing simulator; weekday mornings are emptiest)
 - **Solarium** (adults-only, deck 15 forward; the quiet pool experience)
 - **Ben & Jerry's** (paid, but: sea-day-afternoon ice cream is pleasant)
 - **Vitality Spa thermal suite** (paid day pass — the heated stone loungers are the value here, not the mud rooms)
 - **Card room or library** (deck 14; quietest spot on the ship)

A note on the Royal Promenade: It's a real attraction, but it's also where embarkation-day chaos peaks. After Day 1, walk through it once, see the parade if there is one, and then choose a less central path for daily ship navigation.

Section 2 — Day-by-Day

Day 1 (Saturday) — Embarkation, PortMiami

Check-in window opens at 10:30 AM (verify in your Cruise Planner). Earliest check-in slot is usually 10:30; the ship is boarding by 11:30 most weeks.

The realistic timeline:

- **10:30–11:30 AM:** First-wave check-in, terminal still empty. Drop bags with porter at curb (TIP \$1–2/bag), proceed to security, then Royal's check-in desk, then the gangway.
- **11:30 AM–12:30 PM:** Cabins are usually NOT ready until 1 PM. Plan to drop carry-on outside your cabin door, then head straight to the Windjammer (deck 16) for lunch. Yes it's crowded; yes the food is fine; the alternative is waiting in the terminal.

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- **1:00 PM:** Cabins open. Find your cabin, drop your bags, meet your stateroom attendant. They'll come by — introduce yourself.
 - **1:30–3:30 PM:** Explore the ship at a low intensity. Don't try to see everything. Find your nearest elevator bank, your closest bar, and one quiet spot you'd return to.
 - **3:30 PM:** Mandatory muster drill (now done via the app and an in-person check-in at your assigned station — ~10 minutes total).
 - **4:30 PM:** Sailaway. Best viewing from the Solarium or aft pool deck.
 - **6:00 PM or 8:30 PM:** Dinner. Main dining room or your specialty reservation.

What to pack in your carry-on for Day 1: swimsuit, sunscreen, sunglasses, change of clothes, all medications, a layer (Miami is humid; the ship is air-conditioned), your passport, your phone charger, a refillable water bottle, any embarkation paperwork. Your checked bags may not arrive until 7–9 PM.

Money/card: Your SeaPass card is your ID, room key, and onboard charge. You'll receive it at check-in. Keep it on a lanyard.

The honest first-day mistake to avoid: Don't sign up for the unlimited drink package mid-sail unless you've already done the [drink-calculator](#) math. Decide before you board. Mid-sail upgrades are pricier and give you fewer days of usage.

Day 2 — Sea Day

This is the day you find your rhythm.

Morning: Coffee. Symphony has decent coffee at the Café Promenade (deck 5, free) and very good coffee at Starbucks (deck 5, paid). The Solarium Bistro (deck 15) does an underrated breakfast with smaller crowds than the main Windjammer.

Mid-morning to lunch: Pick ONE big experience to try while the lines are short. Ultimate Abyss, Flowrider, or the Solarium pool. The line for everything will be 4x as long after lunch.

Afternoon: This is where most cruisers get the most value. Options:

- The pool (Solarium for adults, main pool for energy)
- A show in Studio B or the Royal Theater (matinees often)

- Spa day pass or a single treatment (cheaper on sea days when “specials” appear in your stateroom flyer — be skeptical of the markup language; the actual discount is real)
- The Bionic Bar (paid drinks, but the experience is the point)
- An hour of nothing in your cabin or the library

Evening: Dinner at your assigned time, then the headliner show. Symphony’s HiRO in the AquaTheater is the standout if it’s running. If not, the Royal Theater production show is second-tier but still good.

A note for solo travelers: Sea days are when solo cruising can feel either great or lonely. Strategy: pick one shared meal (specialty restaurant communal table, or main dining room shared seating), one shared activity (trivia in Schooner Bar at 11 AM is usually friendly), and one quiet activity. That rhythm works.

Day 3 — Roatan, Honduras

Arrival: Approximately 8:00 AM, depart 5:00 PM. Symphony docks at Mahogany Bay or Coxen Hole; check your Cruise Planner. Mahogany Bay is RC’s purpose-built pier with a small developed area; Coxen Hole is the older town.

The honest read on Roatan: The island is genuinely beautiful — clear water, great snorkeling, friendly locals. It’s also the port where ship-sponsored excursions are noticeably more expensive than independently arranged tours. If you have an opinion about that tradeoff, this is where it matters most.

For each of this week’s three port days, the Port Day Planner builds an hour-by-hour timeline once you drop in your priorities — useful if you’re juggling a half-day excursion and ship-back time. You can also pre-log each port to your Port Logbook before you sail, so the day you actually live becomes something you can compare against the day you planned.

Easy-day option: Stay in the Mahogany Bay/Coxen Hole area, walk around for an hour, return to the ship for lunch in a near-empty Windjammer, and use the afternoon for another sea-day-style activity.

Half-day option: Take a taxi to West Bay Beach (~\$6/person each way, 25 min). White sand, calmer water than West End, several restaurants. Bring cash for beach chairs (~\$10–15/day) and lunch (\$15–25/person).

Full-day option: A snorkel tour to the Mesoamerican Reef (the world's second-largest barrier reef). Independent operators run tours from West End for \$35–55/person; ship excursions run \$80–150/person for similar experiences. Choose ship excursion if you want guaranteed return-to-ship; choose independent if you're a confident traveler with a watch.

For accessibility considerations: Mahogany Bay's developed area is wheelchair-accessible at the pier and shopping zone. Beyond that, Roatan is a developing-country setting; expect uneven surfaces, limited curb cuts, and beach access requiring a portable beach wheelchair (worth bringing if mobility is a priority).

Pack for Roatan: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen (locally enforced), towel, water shoes if snorkeling rocky shores, \$40–60 cash in small bills.

Day 4 — Costa Maya, Mexico

Arrival: Approximately 9:00 AM, depart 6:00 PM. Costa Maya is a Mexican government-built cruise port — purpose-designed for cruise ships. The pier complex itself is large, manicured, and contains shops, restaurants, a small zoo, swimming areas, and excursion meeting points.

The honest read on Costa Maya: Costa Maya is the easiest of the three Mexican ports. Everything is walkable from the ship, beach access is nearby, and the developed area is genuinely pleasant. It's also the least “authentic Mexico” of the three — feels more like a resort than a port town. That's not a value judgment; it's information.

Easy-day option: Stay in the Costa Maya port complex. The Tropicante beach area is a 10-minute walk and offers chairs (\$10–15), drinks, a buffet (for purchase). The pool complex inside the port is free with cruise card.

Half-day option: Mahahual village (~10 min by shared shuttle, \$4/person each way) is a small fishing town turned cruiser stop. The malecón has restaurants, beach access, and shops. Less crowded than the port complex.

Full-day option: Chacchoben Mayan ruins (~45 min by tour bus). The independent tour operators outside the pier offer this for ~\$50/person; ship excursions run ~\$80–100. Worth it if you have any interest in Mayan history; the ruins are smaller than Tulum but less crowded.

For caregivers and slow travelers: Costa Maya is the most accessible of the three Mexican ports. The pool complex inside the gated area is wheelchair-accessible, has shaded loungers, and is only 5 minutes from re-boarding. If a port day might exhaust someone in your party, this is the day to plan a nap-friendly version.

Pack for Costa Maya: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen, light cover-up, \$40–60 cash, small backpack for shopping. You can return to the ship for lunch and nap easily.

Day 5 — Cozumel, Mexico

Arrival: Approximately 9:00 AM, depart 7:00 PM (or later). Symphony docks at one of three Cozumel piers — Punta Langosta (downtown), International Pier, or Puerta Maya. Cozumel is the most heavily visited Caribbean port; expect 3–5 ships in port the same day during peak season.

The honest read on Cozumel: This is the underwater destination of the Western Caribbean. The reef system off Cozumel is world-class. If anyone in your group has ever wanted to try snorkeling, this is the day to do it. Above water, Cozumel feels touristed in a familiar way — it's been a cruise stop for 50 years and the routine is well-established.

Easy-day option: Stay near your pier. Punta Langosta puts you in downtown San Miguel — walk around, find a Mexican lunch (\$15–25/person), shop at Mercado Municipal (the local market, NOT the tourist shops near the pier). International and Puerta Maya are 5–10 minutes from downtown by taxi.

Half-day option: Chankanaab Beach Adventure Park (~\$50/person entry, ~15 min by taxi). Calm water, snorkel rentals, dolphin program (paid extra), lounge and umbrella. Family-friendly.

Full-day option (the snorkel one): Palancar Reef snorkel tour. Multiple operators on the pier offer this for \$40–60/person (ship excursion: \$80–110). Two-hour tour, calm water, abundant fish life. If you've never snorkeled in clear water, this is the trip that converts you. Bring underwater camera.

Full-day option (the historical one): Tulum ruins (3-hour ferry + bus, \$90–150 ship excursion or ~\$80 independent). Long day. Skip in summer if heat-sensitive.

A note on shopping: Cozumel's pier shops sell you the same Mexican blanket, the same silver jewelry, and the same vanilla extract you can buy at any Caribbean cruise port. The interesting shopping is at Mercado Municipal in San Miguel (15 min walk from Punta Langosta) — locals shop there too.

For wheelchair users and limited mobility: Cozumel is genuinely accessible at the piers. Punta Langosta connects directly to a paved boardwalk into San Miguel. Many beach clubs have beach wheelchairs available; ask in advance. Snorkel boats are typically NOT accessible — book a beach-snorkel tour instead of a boat tour.

Pack for Cozumel: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen, water shoes, sun hat, \$60–80 cash for tour and lunch, small underwater camera if you have one.

Day 6 — Sea Day

Your second sea day. By now you know the ship. Use this day to do the thing you wished you'd done on Day 2.

Suggestions you may not have considered:

- **Galley tour** (free, signup at Guest Services on Day 2 or 3 — usually ~\$10/person, fills up fast)
- **Wine tasting** (sea-day afternoons; ~\$25–35/person; a calmer experience than the bars)
- **Bridge tour** (when offered; check Cruise Compass)
- **The 1.7-mile rooftop track** (early morning, before the sun is high)
- **The Solarium for sunset** (deck 15 forward; quietest pool deck on the ship)

Planning ahead: Tonight is usually one of the two formal nights (also called “Dress Your Best Night” on Royal). Check your Cruise Compass — they're typically on Sea Day 2 and Sea Day 5 or whichever is the second-to-last sea night. If you brought formal wear, this is the night.

Day 7 — Perfect Day at CocoCay, Bahamas

Arrival: Approximately 7:30 AM, depart 4:00 PM (sometimes earlier). CocoCay is Royal Caribbean's private island, purpose-built and well-developed. Tendering is not required; the ship docks directly.

The honest read on CocoCay: It is a manufactured experience. It is also genuinely well-executed. The water is gorgeous, the beaches are clean, and almost everything is included in your cruise fare. If you're tired from the previous port days, CocoCay is where you can have a no-decisions beach day.

Free with your cruise fare:

- Chill Island and South Beach (the main free beaches)
- Buffets, burger shacks, and food trucks (multiple locations)
- The Coco Beach Club lazy river (free)
- Lounge chairs (first-come; arrive by 9 AM for shaded ones)
- The Wave Pool and the Splashaway Bay kids' area (Splashaway Bay is for under-12s)
- Bars (drinks are paid unless you have a beverage package)

Paid (\$\$\$) — and worth deciding before you board:

- **Thrill Waterpark** — 13 slides, the world's tallest at the time of build. ~\$45–80/person depending on date. Good for families with kids 7+. Skip if you're an adults-only group.
- **Coco Beach Club** — adults-oriented, dedicated pool, swim-up bar, included food. ~\$110–150/person. Real value if you want a quiet, premium beach day. Lower priority for families.
- **Up, Up, and Away** — helium balloon ride. Photogenic, ~\$100/person, lasts ~10 minutes. Skippable.
- **Cabanas** — at any of three areas. ~\$300–800 for the day. Worth it for groups of 4–6 who'd otherwise spend that on individual paid items.

A note on weather: CocoCay closes occasionally for weather. If your day is cancelled, you'll get a sea-day instead, with the Cruise Director extending operating hours and pushing harder on entertainment. It happens; not common.

Climate at CocoCay. Tropical Bahamas — winter sailings run 70–80°F days, 60s°F at sunrise; summer sailings 80–90°F with serious humidity. The Berry Islands sit in the Atlantic hurricane track (Jun–Nov, peak Sep–Oct); on those months brief 30-minute afternoon showers are common, and Royal Caribbean monitors active systems and reroutes if needed. Water reflection makes the sun feel hotter than the air reads

regardless of season — reef-safe sunscreen earlier and more often than you think. Shaded loungers go first; 9 AM is the latest you want to be off the ship if shade matters. Pull the [CocoCay port page](#) live forecast 24 hours before docking.

Pack for CocoCay: swimsuit (worn aboard or in your beach bag), towel (the ship provides — return them at the end of the day), sunscreen, sun hat, refillable water bottle (free water stations everywhere), \$20–30 cash for tipping.

Day 8 (Saturday) — Disembarkation, Miami

The realistic timeline:

- **5:30–7:00 AM:** Buffet open early. Eat now if your bag is in the hall already.
- **7:00 AM:** Ship cleared by customs. Disembarkation begins for those carrying their own bags (“self-disembarkation,” typically 7:00–7:30 window).
- **7:30–8:30 AM:** First color-coded groups called for assisted disembarkation. Your color and time will be in your Cruise Compass the night before.
- **8:00–9:30 AM:** Most passengers off the ship. Customs and immigration is efficient at PortMiami; expect 15–30 minutes.
- **By 10:30 AM:** Ship empty.

The night before: Pack carefully. Set out clothes for the morning, your toiletries, and your phone charger. Everything else goes in checked bags by 11 PM (your stateroom attendant gives you the disembarkation paperwork on Day 7). Bags get tagged with your color and dropped in the hallway. They’ll be in the cruise terminal in the morning, sorted by color.

Tipping at the end:

- Stateroom attendant and head waiter are auto-gratuitied through your daily service charge (\$16/person/day). Additional cash tip in the envelope they leave on Day 7 is appreciated but not required. \$20–40 per attendant per cabin is reasonable if you want to add.
- Concierge (if you used the suite concierge): \$25–50 in cash, in an envelope.

If you’re staying in Miami a night: Cruise Connections (the bus from PortMiami to MIA airport) runs \$25–35/person. Uber/Lyft is faster (~25 min) but surge-prices on Saturdays. Plan a 12 PM hotel check-in or restaurant lunch as a buffer.

Killing time before an evening flight. The terminals at PortMiami do not store bags — TSA bans cruise-terminal bag storage. Two workable options:

- **Third-party luggage storage.** Radical Storage and Bounce both have host locations in Brickell and downtown Miami (\$5–8/bag/day, book on the app, drop bag with a hotel or shop, walk away). Brickell is a 10-minute Uber from the port.
- **Hotel day-room.** Several Brickell and downtown hotels rent rooms for the day at ~\$60–90 if you book direct and ask. Useful if you want a shower before a long flight.

What to do with the time, given you're already off the ship by 10 AM:

- **Bayside Marketplace** is the closest walk-anywhere option (15 min on foot, or short Uber). Touristy but lunch options and harbor views fill an hour or two.
- **Wynwood Walls** (10-min Uber, \$25–35 for the walls plus the surrounding district): a half-day's worth of street-art photography if you've never been.
- **South Beach** (15-min Uber): Lummus Park, Ocean Drive, a beach walk in your travel clothes. Bring a change of shirt.
- **Vizcaya Museum & Gardens** (15-min Uber, ~\$25): if you'd rather sit somewhere quiet for two hours.

MIA without an Uber. Cruise Connections shared shuttle is the only formal port-to-airport bus and it runs by reservation — book before the cruise. Otherwise: Metromover (free) connects PortMiami to downtown, where Metrorail to MIA runs ~\$2.25 and takes ~30 minutes, but the transfer with bags is rough. **Honest call: budget \$20–30 for Uber/Lyft on a Saturday and don't overthink it.**

Airport-arrival timing. For a domestic flight after 5 PM, leave the port by 2 PM. For an international flight after 7 PM, leave by 3 PM. MIA TSA lines run 30–60 min in the Saturday-afternoon cruise rush; the airport itself is large and the gate walk can add 15 min.

Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

If a milestone-driven view helps you, the site's [Countdown](#) tracks lead time, packing window, and final-payment date against your sail date — pairs naturally with the checkpoints below.

90 days before — booking decisions

- Confirm cabin assignment matches what you booked
- Buy the drink package if you're going to (prices rise as the date approaches)
- Make specialty restaurant reservations
- Book any shore excursions you're committed to (or wait — independent tours often cheaper, especially Cozumel)
- Get/renew passport if expired or expires within 6 months of return
- Buy travel insurance if you want it

60 days before — soft logistics

- Plan your flights to Miami (or drive); arrive Friday before to avoid weather risk
- Book pre-cruise hotel if flying in early
- Reserve airport-to-port transportation
- Apply for any travel-document pre-clearance (TSA PreCheck if applying)

30 days before — final prep window

- Final payment due to Royal Caribbean (already paid for many; check)
- Confirm dietary requirements with cruise line
- Pre-print or save digital copies of: passport, boarding pass, Cruise Planner reservations, travel insurance details
- Online check-in opens (do this immediately — it's how you get your boarding window)
- Order anything you need from Amazon (don't wait until the last week)

14 days before — packing window

- Start the packing list (next section)
- Plan your formal night outfit if going formal
- Get any prescription refills filled (full week + buffer)
- Notify your bank/credit card about international travel (Mexico, Honduras, Bahamas)

7 days before — final logistics

- Confirm your transportation to PortMiami
- Print luggage tags from the Cruise Planner
- Download Royal Caribbean app and pre-load your check-in
- Charge all electronics, headphones, e-reader
- Set your home thermostat to vacation mode

2 days before — arrival prep

- Confirm flight status
- Pack
- Print or save: boarding pass, Cruise Planner reservations, hotel reservation, transportation reservation
- Set out passport + cruise documents in one place

Day before — Miami arrival

- Arrive in Miami Friday afternoon if flying
 - Check into pre-cruise hotel
 - Eat a relaxed dinner; sleep early; the cruise terminal is at 11 AM Saturday
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Section 4 — Packing List (Western Caribbean, 7 nights, Symphony)

This list is calibrated for THIS itinerary: tropical climate, three port days with beach access, two formal nights (typically), one private island, embarkation in Miami in any season. If you'd rather start from a broader checklist than this one-time pack, the [cross-cruise packing-lists page](#) covers the wider catalog (cold-weather sailings, river cruises, transatlantics) that doesn't apply here but might next time.

Documents and money

- Passport (or US passport card + birth certificate; passport is strongly preferred)
- Printed copy of cruise documents (hotel + boarding details)
- Travel insurance card (if applicable)
- \$200–300 USD in small bills for tips, taxis, beach chairs
- 2 credit cards (split between travelers)
- Driver's license (separate from passport, in different bag)

Carry-on (must arrive on the ship with you)

- All medications + 3-day buffer (NEVER in checked bags)
- Phone, charger, headphones
- Swimsuit (cabins not ready until 1 PM; pool is open before that)
- Sunscreen and lip balm
- Layer / light cardigan (the ship is air-conditioned)
- Refillable water bottle
- Empty travel mug for coffee
- 1 change of clothes
- Small bag of snacks for embarkation lunch line
- Phone charger
- Reading material for the embarkation queue

For the ship

- 7 daily outfits (mix of casual and dressy)
- 2 formal night outfits (suit/sport coat for men; cocktail dress / dressy outfit for women) — formal is encouraged, not required
- Comfortable walking shoes (Symphony is large; expect 3–5 miles of walking per day)
- 1 dressier shoe for formal night
- Pajamas
- Light jacket for the Solarium / breezy decks at sunset
- Sunglasses
- Reef-safe sunscreen (Mexico legally requires it)
- After-sun lotion
- Insect repellent (Roatan especially)

Beach gear (port days)

- Beach bag
- Quick-dry towel (the ship provides full towels but lighter ones travel better)
- Water shoes (Roatan and Cozumel have rocky beaches in places)
- Underwater camera or phone waterproof pouch (one IPX8-rated pouch for the family — see our [tech guide](#) if you want a specific recommendation)
- Cash in \$5s and \$10s for beach club tips and beverages

Optional but useful

- Magnetic hooks (4–6 — the cabin walls are steel)
- Over-door organizer for the bathroom (small item, big payoff)
- Lanyard for SeaPass card
- Reusable laundry bag
- Power bank (carry-on only; can charge multiple devices off cabin's single outlet)
- Foam earplugs (for cabin neighbors / hallway noise)
- Sleep mask (the cabin has light leak from hallways and digital clocks)

Skip

- Hairdryer (cabin has one)
 - Iron (banned by Royal — fire safety)
 - Heating pad / electric kettle (banned)
 - Surge-protected power strips (banned)
 - More than 2 bottles of liquor (Royal allows 1 wine + 12 NA cans/bottles per cabin; rest is confiscated and returned at disembarkation)
 - Drone (banned at sea and at most Caribbean ports)
 - Heavy formal wear if you're not going formal — many cruisers wear nice business casual on formal night, that's fine
-
-

Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

The honest cost of a 7-night Western Caribbean for a couple, beyond the cruise fare itself.

What's already included in your cruise fare

- Cabin
- Three meals a day in main dining room and Windjammer
- Pizza, soft-serve, sandwiches at the Promenade, Boardwalk Dog House, Sorrento's
- Most onboard entertainment (shows, AquaTheater, Studio B, comedy)
- Pool deck, fitness center (no equipment fees)
- Most of CocoCay's beach access
- Tips for stateroom attendant and waiters (auto-gratuity at \$16/person/day = \$112/person/week = **already on your bill**)

What's NOT included (typical add-ons)

Item	Couple, 7 nights
Auto-gratuity (already noted)	\$224
Beverage package (Deluxe, both guests)	\$1,400 — IF you both buy it
Beverage package (Refreshment, both guests)	\$480 — IF you both buy it
Specialty restaurant dinners (3 meals × 2 people)	\$200–300
Shore excursions (3 port days, light)	\$300–500
Shore excursions (3 port days, heavy)	\$700–1,000
WiFi (Voom Surf+Stream, 7 nights, 1 device)	\$140
Spa treatments (1 each)	\$200–400
Photo package	\$200–400
Casino, bingo, art auctions	\$0–wide range
Pre-cruise hotel (1 night Miami)	\$150–300
Airport-to-port transfer (round trip)	\$50–100
Tips beyond auto-gratuity	\$50–150

A realistic mid-range budget (couple, 7 nights, beyond cruise fare)

- Cruise fare for 2: ~\$1,800–2,400 (varies wildly by week)
- Auto-gratuity: \$224
- Drink package (Refreshment, both): \$480
- Specialty dinners (3): \$250
- Shore excursions (mix of independent + ship): \$400
- WiFi: \$140
- Pre-cruise hotel + transfer: \$250
- Cash for ports + tips: \$250

Total beyond fare: ~\$2,000. So a \$2,000 cruise fare becomes ~\$4,000 at the door.
Useful to know up front.

If your spending pattern is different from this mid-range example — heavier on excursions, lighter on drinks, or a suite cabin — the [cruise-budget-calculator](#) lets you swap in your own numbers and see the door-total in seconds.

How to spend less

- Skip the drink package; bring 1 bottle of wine + drink at ports
- Eat in main dining room (food is genuinely fine)
- Independent tours in Cozumel and Roatan
- Skip WiFi (the Bahamas has good cell signal at CocoCay; airplane mode for the rest)
- Pack snacks instead of buying at Starbucks
- Skip the photo package; phones are sufficient

How it costs more

- Suite cabin
 - Multi-day spa packages
 - Multiple specialty restaurants per night
 - Casino time
 - Pre-bought “experiences” (ziplining, jetski, etc.)
-
-

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

If you’re reading this in a crisis, the numbers below are the right calls in priority order. Skip to the bold State Department line below if you don’t know where to start. If you’re the cruiser preparing for the trip, fill in the handoff card and share it with one trusted person ashore before sailing. Numbers verified 2026-05-06; cruise-line numbers occasionally change with promotional cycles — confirm yours on your booking confirmation.

This page is part of In the Wake's offline-capable PWA. After your first visit, it works without Wi-Fi — even at sea, in port, or anywhere your family member loses signal.

The family handoff card

Fill in before sailing. Share with one trusted person ashore. Privacy note: passport number and date of birth are sensitive — share with someone you fully trust, and don't email this card unencrypted.

Cruiser's full legal name (as on passport): _____
 Date of birth: _____
 Passport number: _____
 Cruiser's mobile (Wi-Fi calling at sea): _____

Cruise line: Royal Caribbean
 Ship name: Symphony of the Seas
 Sailing date: _____
 Disembark date: _____
 Booking / reservation number: _____
 Stateroom / cabin number: _____

Travel insurance company: _____
 Policy number: _____
 24-hour assistance line: _____

Pre-cruise outbound flight (airline + flight number + date):

Pre-cruise return flight (airline + flight number + date):

Anything to share in a medical situation
 (allergies, medications, conditions, advance directive on file):

Trusted contact at home (cruiser's records):
 Name: _____ Phone: _____ Relationship: _____

Universal 24/7 line — the right call when in doubt

U.S. State Department, Overseas Citizens Services

- From the U.S. or Canada: +1-888-407-4747
- From abroad: +1-202-501-4444
- Available 24 hours a day, every day. They can locate the ship, contact the cruise line on the family's behalf, and coordinate consular services if the situation is in port.

Cruise-line numbers (Royal Caribbean)

The State Department line above is the right call for a true at-sea emergency. The cruise-line numbers below are useful for non-emergency communication (relaying a non-urgent message to the ship, pre-cruise flight delays, billing or booking questions). Per Royal Caribbean's own FAQ, **Royal Caribbean does not publish a separate free 24/7 emergency family-contact desk** — its ship-phone numbers are paid relays that connect a caller to the ship's onboard phone system.

- **Ship-phone relay (paid, non-emergency communication): (888) 724-7447** from U.S. · **(321) 953-9003** international (per [Royal Caribbean's official FAQ](#)). \$7.95 USD/min, billed to MasterCard or Visa; international additionally accrues long-distance charges. Use this for non-urgent messages, not for delivering crisis news.
- **Pre-cruise flight assistance (24/7): 844-278-9745** (Air2Sea)
- **Customer service / general (24/7 day-of-sailing): 800-256-6649** (U.S.) · 305-539-4107 (international)
- **Reservations (Mon–Sun 7 AM – 2 AM ET): 866-562-7625**

For in-port emergencies the ship's port agent is reachable through the cruise line's customer-service desk; the agent's name and direct number for each port appear in the daily program once you board.

U.S. embassies and consulates — this itinerary's ports

- **Bahamas (U.S. Embassy, Nassau)** — Perfect Day at CocoCay falls under Bahamian jurisdiction.
 - Phone: +1-242-461-5025 (24/7; press option 1 for emergencies)
 - Address: 235 Shirley Street, Nassau

-
- **Honduras (U.S. Embassy, Tegucigalpa)** — covers Roatán.
 - Business hours (American Citizen Services): +504-2238-5114 ext. 4400
 - After-hours emergency: +504-2217-5100
 - **Mexico (U.S. Consulate General, Mérida)** — covers Cozumel and Costa Maya.
 - Phone: +52-999-689-0660 from Mexico, or 011-52-999-689-0660 from the U.S.
 - The ship's port agent can also reach the consular agent quickly for cruise-port emergencies.

What each authority will need from you

Have these ready before you call. It cuts panic-call confusion in half.

Calling the State Department: ship name, sailing date, full legal name of the person aboard, your name, your relationship to them, what you know about the situation.

Calling the cruise line ship-phone: booking number, ship name, sailing date, full legal name of the person aboard, cabin number if assigned, your name, your relationship.

Calling an embassy or consulate from a port: your full name (you the caller), passport number if you're abroad, where you are physically right now, what you need, whether anyone is hurt.

Decision tree — which call do I make?

- **Medical emergency at sea** → State Department first; they coordinate with the cruise line.
- **Missing person at sea** → State Department; the Cruise Vessel Security and Safety Act of 2010 requires the cruise line to log incidents and report to the FBI.
- **Port-side emergency** → local emergency services first; embassy/consulate second; State Department third.
- **Pre-cruise flight delay** → Royal Caribbean's Air2Sea flight assistance hotline above.
- *Don't call 911 — it can't reach a ship in international waters.*

-
- *Don't call the cruise line's general booking line — it routes to sales, not emergencies.*

Where to go next

- For the deeper systems explanation (how port agents work, what CVSSA 2010 requires of cruise lines, why ship-to-shore numbers vary by line), see </reaching-someone-at-sea.html>.
-

Section 7 — Seasickness on a Caribbean Cruise

Seasickness is the question most cruisers ask before their first sailing and the topic most cruisers underplan for after. The Caribbean is generally calm — trade winds are steady, swells are modest most of the year — but Symphony is on open ocean for a meaningful share of this trip, and any 7-night sailing will produce some hours of swell that you'll feel.

The honest baseline

Most cruisers, on a Caribbean itinerary on an Oasis-class ship, will not get meaningfully seasick. Symphony's stabilizers handle 70–90% of standard ocean motion. You'll feel the ship in two situations:

- **Open-ocean sea days** when the route or weather puts the ship in chop (Symphony's two sea days on this itinerary are usually the calmest hours of the trip — Western Caribbean tracks are well inside protected water — but rougher days happen)
- **Departure / arrival hours** when the ship is maneuvering in tight ports

If you don't usually get carsick or queasy in other moving environments, the odds you'll get meaningfully seasick on this cruise are low.

If you do get seasick — what works

Five honest options, in order of how often experienced cruisers actually use them:

1. **Look at the horizon.** Free, immediate, scientifically valid. Your inner ear and your eyes are sending mismatched signals; resolving the visual signal with a fixed reference point reduces the mismatch. Going outside is the most effective single thing you can do.
2. **Eat lightly when feeling rough.** Heavy meals + alcohol + ship motion is a worse combination than any individual factor. Skip the buffet line on a rocking sea day; eat a banana, drink water, return to dinner when conditions calm.
3. **Ginger candies or ginger tea.** Genuinely helpful for mild nausea; no side effects; safe with all medications. Pack a small tin in your day bag.
4. **Drug-free wristbands** (acupressure on the P6 wrist point). Some swear by them, others find them theater. Cheap to try; no harm if they don't work for you.
5. **Over-the-counter or prescription medication.** Bonine (meclizine) is generally less drowsy than Dramamine. Scopolamine patches (prescription) are highly effective for severe motion sensitivity but require a doctor visit before the cruise. **Talk to your pharmacist or doctor about which fits your medical context** — we don't link product purchases here because the right answer depends on what else you take, not on what's convenient to buy.

Cabin choice and motion

If motion sensitivity is a real concern, the cabin matters:

- **Midship, lower deck** = least motion. On Symphony, that's roughly Decks 6–10, sections 9–11.
- **Forward and aft cabins** feel more motion. Forward feels pitch (front-back); aft feels yaw (side-to-side) plus engine vibration.
- **Higher decks** feel more roll than lower decks (further from the ship's center of gravity).

If you booked a Boardwalk balcony or Central Park balcony, you're in the inward-facing cabins where the ship's motion is felt least visually. If you booked an ocean balcony at high deck (12+), you'll feel the ship more during chop. Both are real cruises; just know what you booked.

Prevention timing

The pattern most experienced cruisers follow:

- **Night before boarding:** take an oral preventive (Bonine/Dramamine, or apply a scopolamine patch) even if you don't feel queasy yet. Medication is more effective preventively than as treatment.
- **First morning of the cruise:** repeat the dose if a 24-hour formulation isn't on board.
- **First sea day:** repeat once more if needed. By Day 3 most cruisers have adapted and need nothing further.

Skip preventive dosing if you're confident you don't get motion sick — the medication has costs (drowsiness on Bonine, dryness on scopolamine) and shouldn't be taken if not needed.

What NOT to do

- Don't drink alcohol heavily on a rough sea day if you're feeling unwell. The combination is worse than either alone.
- Don't read or stare at your phone in bed during pitching seas. Both create the visual-vestibular mismatch that triggers nausea.
- Don't lie down in a windowless cabin if you can avoid it. Get to a window or deck.
- Don't assume a balcony solves everything — some cruisers feel motion *more* on a balcony because of the rapid visual reference.

A note for travelers with vestibular conditions

If you have a documented vestibular dysfunction — from a service-connected injury, a previous illness, age-related changes, or any other cause — talk to your prescribing doctor before sailing. A “vacation override” for prescription patches is straightforward to arrange but requires lead time. Symphony has a 24-hour medical center on Deck 2 that can manage acute episodes; costs apply (not typically covered by US Medicare or VA coverage at sea).

What to pack (covered earlier in Section 4 too, listed here for ease)

In your medication kit:

- Whichever oral preventive your pharmacist recommended (Bonine/Dramamine + a scopolamine patch as backup if applicable)
 - Ginger candies or ginger tea bags
 - Optional: drug-free wristbands
-

Section 8 — Practical Logistics

The everyday details that no one mentions until they bite. Skim this section once now and once again two weeks before sailing. The detail here is deliberately heavier than in the rest of the pack — these are the questions that, when unanswered, become real problems at the worst possible moments.

Travel documents

A current U.S. passport is the right document for this cruise. It is *technically* possible to sail this 7-night Western Caribbean closed-loop itinerary on a passport card or on a certified birth certificate plus state-issued photo ID — Royal Caribbean accepts those documents under federal “closed-loop” rules — but this is the place where saving \$130 on a passport application becomes a multi-thousand-dollar problem if anything goes wrong.

Three real scenarios where the passport matters and the alternatives don’t:

If you experience a medical emergency at sea or in a foreign port and need to fly home from the closest international airport (Cancún, Roatán’s Juan Manuel Gálvez), only a passport will get you on the airplane. Birth certificates won’t fly. If you miss the ship at a port and need to catch up to it at the next stop, only a passport will let you fly. If your

wallet is stolen in Cozumel and you need an emergency travel document from the U.S. embassy in Mérida, the embassy works much faster when you have a paper copy of an existing passport rather than starting from scratch.

The technical rules for U.S. citizens, in order of practical importance:

- **Passport validity** must extend through your return date. The widely-quoted “six months past return” rule is required for some Caribbean countries (Honduras requires 3 months; Mexico has been lenient but enforcement varies). Even when not strictly required, six months is the sane safety margin. If your passport expires within nine months of your return date, **renew now** — passport processing as of 2026 typically runs 4–8 weeks for routine, 2–3 weeks for expedited.
- **Name match must be exact.** The name on your passport must match your cruise booking exactly — every character, every middle name, every hyphen, every suffix. Royal Caribbean’s automated systems will deny boarding for mismatch. If you legally changed your name since booking, contact Royal the moment you have the legal paperwork. Updates take 2–4 weeks to propagate.
- **REAL ID** applies to your domestic flight to Miami, not to the cruise. TSA began full REAL ID enforcement on **May 7, 2025**, so every domestic flight in the U.S. requires REAL-ID-compliant identification at the TSA checkpoint. Look at your driver’s license: if there’s a star or a flag in the upper right corner, you’re compliant. Otherwise, your options are a REAL ID renewal (varies by state, often requires an in-person DMV visit), or use your passport for the flight.
- **Kids and grandkids** each need their own passport, even infants. There is no “child on parent’s passport” rule in the U.S. anymore. Birth certificates plus photo ID are accepted for closed-loop on minors, but you’ll regret that choice if anything goes wrong.
- **Special situation: minor with one parent or with a grandparent.** Bring a notarized parental consent letter from the absent parent (if living) authorizing the trip. Cruise lines and customs may ask. Templates online; notary at any UPS Store for ~\$15.
- **Non-U.S. passport holders** need to check visa requirements for each port (Cozumel, Costa Maya, Roatan, CocoCay). U.S. citizens don’t need visas for these ports; many other passport holders do.

If you're applying for a first passport and the date feels close, the U.S. State Department offers "expedited at agency" service in major cities (in-person, by appointment, \$60 surcharge). Call the State Department's National Passport Information Center at 877-487-2778 for current options.

Travel insurance

Strongly recommended for a 7-night Caribbean trip. Read this subsection slowly; the math is real.

Why your home insurance is not enough. U.S. health insurance — including Medicare and standard employer-sponsored plans — does not cover medical care outside U.S. waters. Onboard medical visits on Symphony are not covered. Care at hospitals in Cozumel, Roatán, or Costa Maya is not covered. Most importantly, **medical evacuation by helicopter or charter air ambulance** from international waters back to a U.S. hospital is not covered, and that's the line item that gets expensive: a sea-to-shore evacuation typically runs \$30,000–\$80,000; an international air-ambulance flight to a U.S. hospital can run \$150,000–\$300,000.

What good travel insurance covers, in priority order:

1. **Emergency medical evacuation** (the line item that bankrupts uninsured travelers): aim for at least \$250,000 coverage; \$500,000 is comfortable. Non-negotiable for international cruise travel.
2. **Medical care at sea or in port:** at least \$100,000 coverage; \$250,000+ is comfortable.
3. **Trip cancellation:** reimburses cruise fare, hotel, airfare if a covered reason prevents you from sailing.
4. **Trip interruption:** reimburses costs if you have to leave the cruise mid-sail. This is what saves you if you miss the ship at a port and have to fly to catch up.
5. **Baggage delay / loss:** smaller dollar amounts but practical.
6. **24/7 emergency assistance hotline:** all reputable insurers include this.

The "Cancel for Any Reason" (CFAR) upgrade. Standard cancellation requires a covered reason. CFAR covers everything — cold feet, family pet emergency, work demands, you just changed your mind. CFAR typically reimburses 50–75% (not

100%), costs an additional 20–40% on top of the base premium, and **must usually be purchased within 14–21 days of your initial trip deposit**. If you’ve already passed that window, CFAR is no longer available for this trip.

Pre-existing conditions are the most-claimed exclusion. Most insurers offer a **pre-existing condition waiver** that covers these, but it has a strict purchase deadline (usually within 14–21 days of initial trip deposit). Past that deadline, your back pain, your diabetes, your daily medications all become potential claim-deniers.

What to actually do. Buy travel insurance within two weeks of paying your cruise deposit. Get the pre-existing condition waiver. Add CFAR if your situation feels uncertain. Use a third-party insurer, not the cruise line’s bundled offer. Reputable providers: Allianz Global Assistance, Travelex, Travel Guard, IMG, World Nomads. Compare on InsureMyTrip or Squaremouth. Royal Caribbean’s “CruiseCare” is narrower and more expensive than most third-party alternatives.

Onboard money: how the SeaPass card works

Once you board, your **SeaPass card** replaces cash for everything onboard. At check-in on Day 1, you link a credit card to your stateroom account. Throughout the week, every drink, every specialty dinner, every spa treatment, every casino chip — all of it accumulates on your shipboard account. On disembarkation day, your linked card is charged for the total. Royal emails the itemized statement around 5 AM disembarkation morning; review it before leaving the ship.

Credit card vs debit card. Use a credit card if you have one. Royal places a “hold” on the linked card during the cruise — typically 15–30% of expected total charges, refreshed daily. On a debit card, this hold reduces your available cash, sometimes for 3–7 business days *after* the cruise ends. With a credit card, the hold reduces available credit, not cash.

Foreign transaction fees. The card you link should not charge foreign transaction fees. Most modern travel cards have no foreign-transaction fees. If you bring a card that charges 3% on foreign transactions, that 3% applies to your entire cruise bill — meaningful money.

Casino specifics. Royal’s casinos accept your SeaPass card for chips and slot play. The IRS slot-jackpot W-2G reporting threshold rose from \$1,200 to **\$2,000 effective January 1, 2026** (One Big Beautiful Bill Act; the threshold then adjusts annually for

inflation). If you hit a single jackpot above the current threshold, you'll be asked for your Social Security number or ITIN before payout, and the casino issues a W-2G. Bring your SSN if you plan to play seriously. (All gambling winnings remain reportable income regardless of W-2G threshold.)

Cash you'll actually need. The SeaPass handles ~95% of onboard charges. The remaining 5% is cash:

- Porters at PortMiami: \$1–2 per bag, expected, in cash
- Tipping in port (taxi drivers, tour operators, beach club attendants): cash, U.S. dollars, \$5 and \$10 denominations
- Crew members who go above and beyond: a \$5 or \$10 bill in an envelope at end of cruise

A fair budget for cash on a 7-night Caribbean is **\$200–300 per person**, brought as \$5s and \$10s. ATMs onboard charge cash-advance fees; bring the cash from home.

The end-of-cruise bill and disputes. The itemized statement that arrives the morning of disembarkation is your last chance to dispute charges while still on the ship. Errors do happen — wrong cabin charged for someone else's drink, gratuity duplicated, a shore excursion charged twice. Plan to be at Guest Services by 6 AM disembarkation morning if you spot anything questionable.

Tipping etiquette beyond auto-gratuity

Royal Caribbean's daily service charge — currently around \$16 per person per day, totaling roughly \$112 per person for a 7-night — is added automatically to your shipboard account on Day 1. It covers stateroom attendant, dining-room waiters, assistant waiters, and shared service crew. **It is not optional in the cultural sense, but it is technically removable** at Guest Services if you have a service issue. Don't remove it lightly — the auto-gratuity is how the crew is compensated.

Beyond auto-gratuity:

- **Porter at the cruise terminal:** \$1–2 per bag at curb on Day 1 (cash). Underfunding this can result in your bag being "lost" or arriving very late.
- **Stateroom attendant at end of cruise:** \$20–40 per cabin extra, in cash, in the envelope they leave on Day 7. Genuinely optional but appreciated.

-
- **Specialty restaurant servers:** ~10–15% added at the meal if exceptional. The auto-gratuity covers the base.
 - **Bar gratuities:** an 18% gratuity is added automatically to every drink purchase outside the drink package. If you have the package, no further tipping required, but \$1 per drink in cash for a bartender who remembers your order goes a long way.
 - **Concierge (Suite-class):** \$25–50 cash in an envelope at end of cruise.
 - **Taxi drivers in port:** 10–15% on metered fare; round up.
 - **Tour operators in port:** \$5–10/person half-day group tour; \$10–20/person full-day or specialized; \$5–10/person bus driver if separate.
 - **Beach club / cabana attendants:** \$5–10 if they served you drinks throughout the day.

The auto-gratuity is the floor; everything above is genuinely optional. Don't overspend out of guilt. The [cruise-tipping calculator](#) totals auto-gratuity plus the extras above for the whole sailing if you'd rather see one number than build it from line items. For the broader context of why cruise gratuities work the way they do — and what changed across major lines in 2026 — [Cruise Tipping 2026](#) is the longer read.

Port-day safety and what to do if you miss the ship

Port-day rhythms in the Caribbean are well-established but vigilance matters. The detail here is deliberate; the consequences of getting it wrong are real.

Choosing a taxi. At every Western Caribbean port, licensed taxis are easy to identify — clear markings, government-issued ID badges visible, either a meter or a posted official rate sheet. In Cozumel, licensed taxis are regulated by the **Sindicato de Choferes Taxistas de Cozumel** (the local drivers' union); cabs are white with a red side stripe and clearly numbered on the front doors, and drivers wear ID. In Costa Maya, the licensed taxi stand is at the pier exit (the port is a closed compound, so you generally only encounter licensed drivers). In Roatán, the cruise-port taxi cooperative serving Mahogany Bay is the **Mahogany Bay Taxi Association (MBTA)**; for Coxen Hole and elsewhere on the island, several smaller licensed associations operate — confirm posted rates before riding. Use only licensed drivers. If a driver tells you the meter is broken, walk to the next driver — common scam.

Currency at ports. USD is widely accepted in Mexico, Honduras, and Bahamas (CocoCay is essentially USD-only). Small bills (\$5s, \$10s, \$20s) are most useful.

Pickpocketing and personal awareness. Pickpocketing is not endemic at any of the Western Caribbean cruise ports but it does happen. Don't pull out a phone at the pier or near tour-vendor crowds. Phone in a hard-to-reach pocket; passport and main money in a hotel-style internal money belt or zipped inside-jacket pocket.

Common scams to be aware of (not to fear). They mostly involve pressure-selling: pier-side "free" guided walks that turn into shop-stop tours, fake "official" tour vendors, taxi drivers who claim the meter is broken, "watch your bag" offers that result in bag-disappearance. Politely decline, walk away, don't engage. None escalate beyond financial pressure.

If you miss the ship at a port (the "all aboard" deadline). This happens, more often than cruise lines admit. The cruise line's "all aboard" time is typically 30 minutes before sailaway. If you're not back at the pier by all-aboard, the ship sails without you. Here's the actual protocol:

1. **First, call the ship's port agent immediately.** The contact information is in your Cruise Compass (Royal's daily program, delivered to your cabin each evening) and on the ship's app.
2. **The port agent will advise on next steps.** Typically: catch up to the ship at the next port. For this Western Caribbean itinerary, the next stop after Roatán is Costa Maya; after Costa Maya is Cozumel; after Cozumel is the return to Miami.
3. **You are responsible for the catch-up cost.** Flights from Caribbean ports to other Caribbean ports run \$300–600. A hotel night in the missed port runs \$100–250.
4. **Travel insurance with "trip interruption" coverage reimburses this** if you have it.
5. **Bring your passport in port, not in your cabin safe.** This is the strongest argument for actual passport over passport card or birth certificate.
6. **Time zones — read the Cruise Compass before each port.** Symphony keeps "ship time" — usually U.S. Eastern Time on a Caribbean run from Miami. Two notes that surprise people: (a) Cozumel and Costa Maya are in Mexico's **Quintana Roo state, which observes Eastern Standard Time year-round (UTC–5) and never changes for daylight saving** — so during U.S. EDT months, the local clock is one hour *behind* ship time, and during EST months they match. (b) Roatán (Honduras) is on Central Standard Time year-round (UTC–6). Symphony may stay on ship time even when docked, so the *only* clock that matters for re-boarding is ship time. Confirm in your Cruise Compass the night before each port.

See [Section 6 — Emergency Contacts](#) for the full contact list and the family handoff card.

Special diets, allergies, and religious dietary needs

Notify Royal Caribbean at booking (via Cruise Planner) AND have any group host confirm the request was logged. The ship's kitchen is genuinely capable of accommodating a wide range of dietary needs, but advance notice matters.

Severe food allergies (peanut, tree-nut, shellfish, egg, dairy, soy). Royal takes severe allergies seriously: log the allergy in your reservation at booking. Mention again at check-in. On Day 1, ask your dining-room waiter to introduce you to the head waiter — they coordinate with the kitchen to flag your meals. The kitchen prepares severe-allergy meals separately to prevent cross-contamination. If your allergy is anaphylactic-grade, bring two epinephrine auto-injectors regardless.

Celiac disease and gluten sensitivity. Royal has dedicated gluten-free menus across all dining venues. The risk on a cruise is cross-contamination: the Windjammer buffet is the highest risk. Main dining and specialty restaurants are far safer because the kitchen prepares your meal individually.

Diabetic and low-sugar dietary management. Both main dining and the Windjammer have extensive options. Tell your dining-room waiter on Day 1. Insulin storage in the cabin requires a refrigerated location — most cabins have a small fridge; if yours doesn't, Guest Services will provide a small medical fridge on request (free).

Kosher and Jewish dietary observance. Royal has limited kosher options. Some ships carry frozen pre-packaged kosher meals on request, prepared in advance and reheated. These need to be requested at booking, not the day of.

Halal observance. Generally available on request, supply is limited.

Vegan and vegetarian. Well-supported across all Royal venues. Main dining has dedicated options. No advance notice needed.

Laundry on board

Symphony does not have self-service laundry rooms (Royal removed these years ago).

- **Full-service laundry:** \$5–40 depending on items. Per-item pricing: T-shirts \$3–4, dress shirts \$6–8, pants \$7–9. Submit a bag at your cabin; turnaround typically 24 hours.
- **Pressing service:** \$4–8 per item, 12–24 hour turnaround. Useful for formal nights.
- **Mid-cruise wash & fold deal:** Royal frequently runs a “stuff a bag for \$30” promotion mid-week. Watch your Cruise Compass; not always advertised in advance. If you packed light (3–4 outfits + the wash & fold deal mid-week), you genuinely don’t need more luggage.
- **Dry cleaning:** \$15–30 per item, 48-hour turnaround.
- **What not to send:** items that bleed dye, items that shrink, items with sentimental value.
- **Travel hack:** hang a wrinkled formal outfit in the cabin bathroom and run a hot shower for 5 minutes with the door closed. The steam relaxes most light wrinkles. Saves the pressing fee.

Lost items and lost-and-found

Onboard:

- **Call Guest Services or visit the desk.** They have a centralized lost-and-found that holds items for 90 days post-cruise.
- **End-of-cruise reconciliation.** If you notice something missing on Day 6 or Day 7, deal with it at Guest Services *before* disembarkation.
- **High-value items.** Ship security has CCTV throughout common areas. If you suspect theft rather than misplacement, ask for security’s involvement.
- **The cabin safe.** Use it. Keys, wallets, passports when in port (carry the passport with you; keep the rest in the safe). The safe code is set by you on Day 1.

In port:

- **Items lost in port** are reported to local police, not to the ship. Each port has a tourist police office near the cruise terminal. Get a written police report — your travel insurance will require it.
- **Lost passport in port.** The U.S. Embassy or Consulate in each country issues emergency travel documents (24–72 hours minimum). The ship’s port agent will

advise on hotel and transportation. Travel insurance's trip-interruption coverage applies to the catch-up costs.

- **Items confiscated at security.** Banned items (surge protectors, irons, drones, certain medications) are typically held in secure storage and returned at disembarkation.

Document copies. Before sailing, scan or photograph: passport ID page, driver's license, credit cards (front and back), travel insurance card, medication list. Email these to yourself and to one trusted family member.

Photography and privacy onboard

Ship photographers. Royal stations photographers at common moments — gangway on Day 1, dinner sittings, formal nights, character meet-and-greets. Print packages cost \$40–200; digital packages cost \$200–500. The math rarely works compared to phone photos, but the formal-night portrait is genuinely well-lit; many couples buy that one specific photo and skip the rest. Decline pressure is low.

Kids photo policy. Royal photographers do not photograph minors without parental consent.

Social media at sea. WiFi on Symphony is metered or capped depending on your package. Save large uploads for port-day cellular or after the cruise.

Casino photography is restricted. No phones at gaming tables. Photos elsewhere onboard are generally fine.

Cabin privacy. The *do not disturb* sign on the cabin door is respected. The cabin attendant comes in twice a day; opt out via the sign if you want privacy.

A note for grieving travelers. Some cruisers will be processing a recent loss. Photos and social media can intensify grief. There is no obligation to participate in the visual record of the trip. The Solarium and the library on Symphony are particularly camera-light environments.

Faith resources at sea

Royal Caribbean is a secular cruise line with reasonable accommodation for faith-aware travelers.

Sunday morning interfaith service. Typically held in a small lounge or theater venue at 9 or 10 AM Sunday. Hosted by a senior officer, not by clergy. Order of service: a few hymns, a Scripture reading, brief reflection, prayer. Theologically generic. 30–45 minutes.

Catholic Mass. Available when a Catholic chaplain is sailing. Chaplain rotation is not predictable per sailing.

Jewish Sabbath observance. Friday-evening candle-lighting is generally unscheduled but Guest Services can arrange a designated quiet space for Sabbath services if requested in advance.

Other faiths. Not standard infrastructure on a mass-market cruise line. Guest Services will accommodate respectful requests for quiet space.

Quiet places for personal devotion. The library on Deck 14 (quiet during the day), the Solarium on Deck 15 forward (adults-only, sunrise prayer is real), the chapel-style room used for ceremonies. Ask at Guest Services.

Pastoral content on the broader site. [/solo/](#) addresses cruising in grief, the meaning of moving water, and the way solo travel can become spiritual practice. Several articles are gently faith-aware.

Post-cruise: refunds, disputes, and the cruise blues

Refunds and billing disputes. The end-of-cruise statement that arrives Day 8 morning is the official record. Disputes are easier handled at Guest Services on the ship Day 7 evening or Day 8 early morning than after disembarkation. Common dispute categories: wrong charge applied, shore excursion that didn't deliver, booking-level disputes. Royal processes shore-excursion refunds post-cruise via Royal Caribbean Guest Relations (allow 2–4 weeks).

Post-cruise blues. Real phenomenon. After a week of structured rhythm, sun, saltwater, and the absence of ordinary-life decision-making, returning to email and laundry can feel hollow for several days. It's not a problem to solve; it's a transition to feel through.

What experienced cruisers report works:

- **Don't unpack the suitcase for two days.** Preserves the trip mentally.

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- **Plan a debrief dinner with someone you met onboard 2–3 weeks out.** The trip becomes a story you tell.
 - **Don't book the next cruise immediately.** Some find it hopeful; others find it avoidant. Sit with the blues for a week first.
 - **Stay in touch with anyone you connected with.** Cruise-formed friendships are real if you maintain them.
 - **Notice what the trip taught you about your daily life.** A week of sleep, sun, and slow meals often surfaces the parts of your ordinary routine that feel off.
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Section 9 — Accessibility Notes

For travelers using mobility devices, with chronic illness, sensory needs, or who travel with caregivers:

On the ship

Symphony is one of the more accessible large cruise ships built. Specifics:

- **Accessible cabins** exist in every category (interior, balcony, suite). Book the specific cabin number at booking — Royal does not always honor “wheelchair accessible request” without a confirmed assignment.
- **Elevators** are abundant but during peak times (post-show, pre-dinner) wait times can hit 5–10 minutes. Plan accordingly.
- **Buffet (Windjammer):** lower self-service counters, staff will plate for you on request.
- **Specialty restaurants:** all accessible at table level; some require pre-arrangement for power-chair pathing (call ahead).
- **Pools:** chairlifts at the main pool. Solarium has a zero-entry option in some refurb states; confirm.
- **Theater:** dedicated wheelchair seating in the front and back of Royal Theater.

At ports

- **Miami (PortMiami):** fully accessible, including embarkation gangway.
- **Roatan (Mahogany Bay):** pier and shopping zone accessible. Beyond that, limited.
- **Costa Maya:** most accessible of the Mexican ports — port complex is well-designed.
- **Cozumel (Punta Langosta):** pier and immediate downtown accessible. Mercado Municipal less so.
- **CocoCay:** surprisingly accessible — the main paths are paved, beach wheelchairs available at the harbor (request at the welcome desk). Free.

For travelers with chronic illness / fatigue

- Schedule one rest day per port — meaning, plan to be back on the ship by 1 PM that day.
- Sea Day 2 and Sea Day 6 are your real recovery days.
- The Solarium is the calmest space on the ship; it's where you go when you need quiet.
- Do not feel pressure to “do” every port. CocoCay is sufficient relaxation by itself.

Connecting with the ship's medical center

Symphony has a 24-hour medical facility on Deck 2. Costs apply (not covered by US Medicare). Bring a copy of your medication list and any specialist contacts.

Section 10 — Solo Traveler Notes

If you're sailing alone:

The cabin question

Royal Caribbean's "single supplement" applies to most cabins — you pay 200% of double-occupancy for sole occupancy. There are exceptions and occasional waivers, but plan on the math.

Where to find people

- **Schooner Bar trivia (11 AM, sea days)** — the friendliest organized social activity
- **Specialty restaurant communal tables** — ask the host for "shared seating" at booking
- **The Solarium** — quiet but surprisingly social; people are reading, then talking
- **Latte-tude Café (free coffee, deck 5)** — quiet morning crowd, good for low-stakes conversation
- **Studio B late-night skating practice** — informal, friendly, mostly empty in late hours

What to expect

Solo cruising on Symphony works because the ship is large enough that you have privacy when you want it and crowds when you want them. The risk is that the daily structure of a cruise (dinner at the same time, repeated shows) can feel lonely without a partner. Build in friendship rituals: the same morning coffee spot, the same trivia hour, the same evening sunset deck.

Solo safety — cabin and onboard

Solo cruising is overwhelmingly safe — cruise ships are among the most surveilled travel environments on earth. But a few habits make sense:

- **Cabin door:** use both deadbolt and privacy latch at night. A portable doorstop / wedge is a cheap extra for peace of mind.
- **Share your itinerary:** before sailing, send the day-by-day to one trusted person ashore.
- **Photo a copy of your passport** and email it to yourself. If the original is lost or stolen, U.S. Embassy replacement is faster with a digital copy.

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- **In port, walk with a fellow cruiser when possible.** Stay in well-trafficked tourist areas, especially first port.
 - **Onboard friendliness ≠ obligation.** A friendly conversation at trivia is not an invitation to dinner. You set the pace; “no thanks” is always available.
 - **The ship has 24-hour security.** If a situation onboard makes you uncomfortable, Guest Services or security is available immediately.

A note for grieving travelers

If this trip is a “getting back to normal” trip after loss, the Solarium and the library on deck 14 are the gentlest spaces on the ship. Sea days are for rest, not for forced socializing. You don’t have to do anything you don’t want to do. The point is movement and quiet water, not performance.

Section 11 — First Cruise Notes

If this is your first cruise: the [first-cruise reference page](#) covers the broader orientation across cruise lines (boarding, dining systems, daily rhythm), and the [Ship Quiz](#) walks you through the line-up if Symphony turns out to be the wrong fit after reading this section. The [Cruising Duck tradition](#) is the one piece of cruise culture worth knowing in advance — bring or hide a few rubber ducks if you want a friendly, accidental social ritual.

What surprises first-time cruisers

1. **The ship is a destination.** You don’t need to do excursions at every port; sea days are part of the experience.
2. **Dinner is a real event.** Even on casual nights, the main dining room is a 90-minute affair. Plan for it.
3. **Tipping is automatic.** \$16/person/day for stateroom + waiters is added to your bill. No additional cash needed unless you want to.

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4. **WiFi is slow and expensive.** Plan to be partially offline. The site's [internet at sea guide](#) explains why.
 5. **The drink package math is real.** Don't assume it's a deal — calculate it for your actual drinking patterns.
 6. **You'll meet people.** Cruisers are friendly. Conversations happen in elevators, in trivia, in line at the buffet.

What we wish we'd known

- Pack one outfit you'd be happy in for ALL formal occasions, not three.
- Skip the ship excursion in Cozumel for snorkeling; book independent at the pier.
- Don't try to optimize Day 1. Eat at the buffet, rest, accept that the cabin is small at first glance.
- The Cruise Compass arrives in your stateroom each evening with the next day's events. Read it; mark the things you want.
- Charge EVERYTHING in your one cabin outlet at night, USB-multi-charger or not. There's no "wait" mode for charging on the ship.

What you don't need to do

- You don't need to be at every show.
 - You don't need to attend the captain's reception.
 - You don't need to take ship-sponsored photos.
 - You don't need to buy art at the art auction.
 - You don't need to participate in the "platinum"/"diamond"/"crown and anchor" loyalty events on your first cruise.
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Continue planning on the site

A few threads worth pulling on the rest of the site as your sailing date approaches.

About your ship

- **Video walkthroughs of Symphony of the Seas** — short clips of public spaces, dining venues, and deck areas, gathered on her [video highlights section](#).
- **Logbook entries from other travelers** — what other guests noticed aboard, in their own words, on the [Symphony logbook section](#) of her ship page.
- **Deck plans and the first-look gallery** for orientation before you board: [first look](#) and [deck plans](#).

About the ports

Each port we visit has its own page on the site, with restaurant pointers, walking-distance notes, and traveler observations gathered over many sailings:

- [Cozumel port page](#)
- [Roatán port page](#)
- [Costa Maya port page](#)
- [Perfect Day at CocoCay port page](#)

Other Voyage Packs

The [full Voyage Packs catalog](#) lists every itinerary we've packed — useful if you're considering a different ship, season, or audience.

Closing

This pack exists to make one cruise easier. It's calmer than most planning content, by design. The site that produced it is independent — no cruise-line money, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads. If you found this useful, the [Support page](#) is where the funding for this kind of work comes from.

Share or save. The HTML version of this pack has a floating share bar (lower-right on desktop) — copy a link, ping a friend on WhatsApp, or generate a QR code if you’re showing someone the page in person. If you find your own little crew of cruisers during the week, an Instagram or X post tagged with the cruise line and ship helps the next first-time Symphony cruiser find writeups like this one.

If this Voyage Pack is the right shape for your trip but the wrong itinerary, [more Voyage Packs](#) cover other lines and routes. The site’s editorial [audit log](#) shows how content here gets reviewed if you want to see the trail.

Soli Deo Gloria. Have a good week at sea.

About this document

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Sources	All data from <code>cruisinginthewake.com</code> data corpus
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